Afghan government on one hand, and reached out to the Afghan Taliban (sometime through, and sometime despite, Karzai) on the other. Having polarised the Afghan domestic political landscape along pro-Karzai and anti-Karzai lines, with a healthy doze of ethnic politicking thrown in, Karzai had left no options for India but to engage with all stakeholders to different degrees (though keeping him as the lynchpin of its approach towards Afghanistan).

Both Narayanan and Saleh's national security-related careers came to an end in 2010. While Narayanan peacefully retired after an illustrious career in the government and was made the governor of West Bengal, Saleh was fired (along with the powerful interior minister Atmar) for failing to foil a Taliban rocket attack on the 2010 peace Jirga. Rahmatullah Nabil, Karzai's confidante, took over from Saleh, and Menon, a conciliator, took over the reigns from Narayanan.[80] Occurring in the wake of Karzai's victory in the 2009 national elections and the momentous London conference in January 2010 that pushed for reconciliation with the Afghan Taliban, Nabil and Menon's security leadership led to critical qualitative shifts in how these countries dealt with the Afghan Taliban (which had an upper hand against Kabul), and treated the issue of reconciliation. As the next section shows, the changing nature of domestic Afghan politics and the coalition forces' desire to reconcile with the Afghan Taliban shifted India's Afghanistan policy into a decisive conciliatory mode in 2010. By 2011, India stopped resisting the good-Taliban/bad-Taliban paradigm altogether.[81]

Accommodating the 'Afghan' Taliban

Appreciative of the Afghan Taliban's internal distinctions, and a conciliator who believed that not all Afghan Taliban were Pakistan's proxy warriors, Menon ordered his deputies to engage further with the Afghan Taliban.[82] The only untouchable group was the Haqqani network with whom 'there is no question [of engagement]' as they 'are quite happy to be used by the Pakistanis', said Menon.[83] Home Minister P. Chidambaram, a Congress heavyweight from Tamil Nadu who had earlier challenged Narayanan's near-total control of India's security bureaucracy, Vice President Hamid Ansari, and India's Special Envoy to Afghanistan and Pakistan Satinder K. Lambah, supported Menon in his strategic